▶ WEST BENGAL

SUVENDU'S CLEAN-UP CREW

A refurbished Anti-Corruption Branch gets cracking on a long-festering sore in Bengal: institutional corruption. The flagship initiative will be tested on its reach

By **Arkamoy Dutta Majumdar**

the notes and is caught, his hands are dipped in sodium carbonate solution. Their hands turn pink or purple with guilt! The entire process is recorded.

A CONTRASTING POSE

On August 6, shortly after the ACB was revamped by the Suvendu Adhikari regime, Saha became its first arrest. That launched a key project for the new BJP dispensation. Institutional corruption, as perceived and experienced by the public, was an albatross around the neck for the erstwhile Trinamool regime. The BJP aims to hunt it down in visible ways—the ACB is its special purpose vehicle. Though set up in 2012, its last arrest was in 2022—the convalescence tells a tale. Now, it's been outfitted for war with three IPS officers. Murli Dhar is the Inspector General.

By now, the ACB has cracked 19 cases and made 26 arrests. Saha's arrest was even mentioned by the CM in a social media post as a "clear message to all" about "zero tolerance" for corruption. He has also launched a helpline and email address for whistleblowers. Sources say a web-based app is on the way as well. "Our workload has spiked," says a senior ACB official, happily.

The agency has dismantled a decade-old extortion syndicate allegedly targeting truck drivers and involving traffic sergeants—one of the latter in Kolkata police, Sanjib Nandi, tipped off the ACB; 15 of his peers from Howrah and Kolkata have been grilled so far. The syndicate, involving multiple touts, collectors and complicit cops across jurisdictions, allegedly extorted up to Rs 2,500 per truck at Dankuni to bypass no-entry rules and evade challans.

The ACB's arrest rate is impressive, given that it works with a skeletal staff of 80-odd people. A source claims ACBs of Odisha and Telangana run with close to a thousand people. "We have made a request for more manpower," says the insider. "We also hope to open a unit in Siliguri to cater to North Bengal. Running around the entire state with so little manpower is difficult."

The bureau believes its actions are creating a deterrent. The question is whether it can move beyond lower-level officials and get the "big sharks" operating in Bengal's power corridors. That could determine whether the BJP's anti-corruption promise holds up as a genuine reset or merely an optically satisfying face job—with nice pink tones. ■



RED-HANDED CATCH Engineer Bimal Saha (left) caught taking a bribe in cash coloured purple by the Anti-Corruption Branch, Aug. 6

Takeaways

- **After a CM-led overhaul in August, ACB has cracked 17 cases, made 24 arrests**
- **Invested with new helpline to aid whistleblowers; one case saw a syndicate busted**
- **BJP's intention, ending TMC-era 'graft culture', will be tested with how far it goes**